

SHORT COMMUNICATIONS

The Boreal Owl as a Pleistocene Relict in Colorado.—The few records for the Boreal Owl, *Aegolius funereus* (Linn.), in Colorado reveal only that the species occurs in the central mountains of that state in autumn and winter. Four records of adults have been obtained between 1882 and 1929, and all of these were between 14 October and "December," with two in November. These records are based on specimens in the Denver Museum of Natural History and at the Colorado State College in Greeley and upon a citation by Bent (U.S. Nat. Mus. Bull., 170:227, 1938). It has been inferred that in winter the Boreal Owl spreads or migrates regularly from its breeding range in Canada approximately to the northern limits of the western United States and sporadically and rarely as far south as Crested Butte, Gunnison County, in central Colorado (AOU Check-list, 1957:289). A recent observation, however, provides fairly strong evidence that the Boreal Owl is a permanent resident in Colorado.

A juvenile female was collected by Koplin on 14 August 1963 in spruce-fir-lodgepole pine forest at Deadman Lookout, 10,700 feet elevation, Larimer County, north-central Colorado (fig. 1). When shot at 2000, this bird was in company with another juvenile, which was still in the area calling at 2100. The bird collected was in juvenile plumage, except for the face, which was heavily in molt. Postjuvenile molt had recently started in the ventral and spinal tracts and in the coverts of upper and under surfaces of the wings. The remiges and rectrices were not molting. Measurements were: wing (primaries pressed straight on ruler) 180.0 mm, tail (from edge of skin at insertion of feather) 108.0, bill from cere 15.1, body weight 152.3 g. Each of the linear measurements was found to be within the range of the corresponding measurement made from a series of 10 female specimens (seven adults, three juveniles with fully grown remiges and rectrices) of *A. f. richardsoni* from the Museum of Vertebrate Zoology, Berkeley, and the U.S. National Museum. A recently ingested specimen of *Phenacomys intermedius* was recovered from the digestive tract. The accompanying owl was seen at close range. It had the same white face together with brown breast and belly, whereas an adult bird would have shown extensive white markings ventrally. It appears that these birds were part of a family group that originated in the Deadman area.

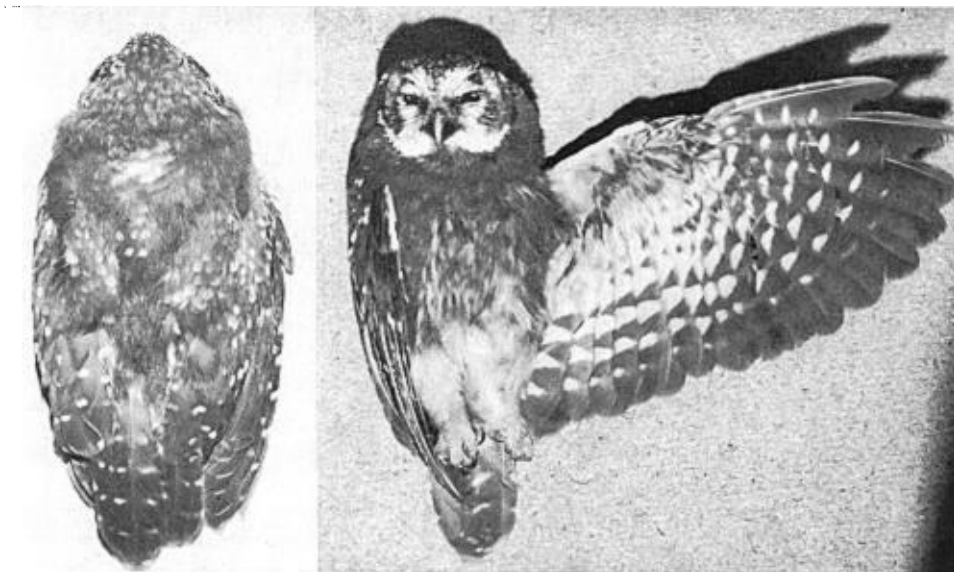


Figure 1. Dorsal and ventral views of juvenile Boreal Owl collected in north-central Colorado on 14 August 1963. The owl is approximately 25 cm in length.

Would a juvenile Boreal Owl from Canada have been approaching the extreme southern limit of its known winter movement in midsummer and fully two months in advance of the earliest known autumnal date for a Boreal Owl in that region? How likely is it that two juveniles would make this "migration" together, or, if separately, meet in this area some 1600 miles south of the Canadian breeding range? The attributes of this record, including the locality, the time of year, the age of the specimen, and the occurrence of two individuals of this age together, are plausibly explained on the basis that these birds originated in the southern locality where they were encountered. Moreover, the presence of these juvenile birds in Colorado in mid-August raises doubts as to the migrant status of the earlier specimens of Boreal Owl from the mountains of Colorado; it is entirely possible that all of these birds were resident owls.

A local breeding population of the Boreal Owl probably occurs in Colorado as a relict of a more widespread midlatitudinal Pleistocene population of Boreal Owls. Fossil bones matching *A. f. richardsoni* have been found in a Pleistocene (or Recent) cave deposit in southern New Mexico (Howard, Condor, 33:216, 1931). The degree of isolation of the Colorado unit is not known and may depend on the possible occurrence of other such units in mountainous areas north of Colorado. As Voous (Atlas of European Birds, 1960:178) has recently illustrated, the Boreal Owl is distributed across Asia in a northern belt but with several small, isolated breeding places in mountains south of the continuous range. The occurrence in the New World of a similar isolated breeding unit south of the continent-wide breeding range is not surprising. Indications that the Boreal Owl is a relatively nonmigratory and, in fact, quite sedentary species are given by Voous (*ibid.*:158) for the Asian forms and by Bent (*ibid.*) for the North American race.

The foregoing observations were made during an investigation of animals associated with woodpeckers in the spruce-fir forests of Colorado supported by the National Science Foundation (Grant GB-753) and the Rocky Mountain Forest and Range Experiment Station of the U.S. Forest Service through its Cooperative Aid program.—PAUL H. BALDWIN and JAMES R. KOPLIN, *Department of Zoology, Colorado State University, Fort Collins, Colorado.* (Present address of Koplin: *Department of Biological Sciences, State University of New York at Albany, Albany, New York.*) 24 September 1965.

Curlew Sandpiper in Ontario.—On 11 September 1965 a Curlew Sandpiper (*Erolia ferruginea*) was found by Daniel Salisbury and Adrian Dorst and party at Grant Point, Ontario, a rocky point on the north shore of Lake Erie 3.5 miles southwest of Port Maitland (about 43 miles west of Buffalo, N.Y.). The bird was associating chiefly with a Pectoral Sandpiper (*Erolia melanotos*). It was collected by Dorst and proved to be a male (testes, 2.5 and 2.3 mm) in slightly worn fall plumage with measurements in millimeters as follows: wing (chord), 125; tail, 51; exposed culmen, 32.7; tarsus, 27.8. The collection of this bird came at the end of a three-week period, during which we heard of several Curlew Sandpiper sightings.

This is the second specimen of this principally Old World species taken in Ontario, the first being an adult, apparently a female, in spring plumage, secured at Toronto about 1886 (McIlwraith, The Birds of Ontario, Jour. and Proc. Hamilton Assn., 1 [part 3]:2, 1886). To date there have been three sight records of single individuals in the province: 11–13 October 1954, Dundas (G. W. North); 2 October 1959, Hamilton (A. J. V. Mason); 21–23 October 1961, Whitby (T. Hassall, G. Norris). The 1961 bird was photographed, and the picture is in the Royal Ontario Museum at Toronto as is the 1886 specimen. Mr. Dorst donated the 1965 specimen to the Buffalo Museum of Science, where it bears BSNS No. 5072. James L. Baillie of the Royal Ontario Museum kindly supplied us with the previous Ontario records.

The Curlew Sandpiper was recorded several times on Long Island in the late 19th century and more frequently in this century, particularly on the Jones Beach strip from 1937 to 1941. In the Jamaica Bay area it has been reported with great regularity since 1947 (Bull, Birds of the New York Area, 1964:206–207), and in New Jersey it has been found for at least 10 consecutive years to 1964 (Scott and Cutler, Aud. Field Notes, 18:441, 1964). Fifty per cent of